

How to Use Claude Code + OpenClaw for FREE with Ollama

Guide by @[therealjerrywu](#)

Overview

This guide shows you how to run Claude Code and OpenClaw completely free by using local AI models through Ollama — no paid Claude API or API tokens required.

What You Need

- [Ollama](#) – a free tool for running AI models locally
- *A local model* – recommended: GLM 4.7 Flash (powerful, free, runs locally)
- [Claude Code](#) - the coding agent you want to power with a free model
- [OpenClaw](#) (optional) – the new AGI... jokes aside, it's a personal assistant that runs 24-7, which also works with Ollama

Step 1 — Install Ollama

1. Go to
2. [ollama.com](#)
3. and download Ollama for your OS (Mac, Windows, or Linux).
4. Install and launch Ollama — make sure it's running in the background before proceeding.

Step 2 — Pull a Local Model

1. Open your terminal.
2. Run the following command to download GLM 4.7 Flash:

`ollama run glm4:flash`

3. Wait for the model to download and confirm it's running locally.

Note: You don't have to use GLM 4.7 Flash. Other options include:

- Gemma 3B – ultra-lightweight, good for low-spec machines
- Google Gemma 34B – lightweight yet powerful, even runs on mobile
- GLM5 – available on Ollama, but is cloud-based (not truly local/free 24/7)

Step 3 — Connect Claude Code to Ollama

1. Open a new terminal window.
2. Run the command to launch Claude Code pointed at your local Ollama model:

`ANTHROPIC_BASE_URL=http://localhost:11434 claude`

Claude Code will now use GLM 4.7 Flash (or whichever model you have running) instead of the paid Claude API.

Step 4 — Connect OpenClaw to Ollama (Optional)

1. Open OpenClaw.

2. In the gateway/settings, configure it to use the Ollama local endpoint.
3. When prompted, click "Yes, proceed".
4. You should see a confirmation message like: *"Gateway is configured with OpenClaw 2 — running through Ollama Studio with GLM 4.7 Flash."*

Step 5 — Verify It's Working

Run a quick test prompt in either Claude Code or OpenClaw:

"What API are you running on?"

Expected response: *"You are running through Ollama Studio with GLM 4.7 Flash currently loaded."*

Key FAQs

Is this truly free?

Yes — as long as you're running a local model via Ollama, it's free 24/7 with no token limits.

Am I using the real Claude API?

No. You're using Ollama's API powering Claude Code's interface. The underlying model is local (e.g. GLM 4.7 Flash), not Anthropic's Claude.

Can it write real code?

Absolutely. GLM 4.7 Flash is one of the top-performing open-source models and is fully capable of coding tasks.

Does this work on Windows?

Yes. the process is the same. Check the Ollama website for Windows-specific installation instructions.